

These throttling test results were mirrored in real-world performance. The Phone (2a) exhibited minimal throttling in my tests, even when running intensive games like Call of Duty: Mobile and BGMI. Additionally, the phone remained relatively cool even after gaming for half an hour. Therefore, while the Nothing Phone (2a) may not be the most powerful in its price segment, it offers exceptionally smooth and snappy performance, primarily due to its UI. Let's delve into that.

UI

The Nothing operating system has undergone significant evolution over the past couple of years, making it one of my favourite Android skins currently available in the market. The Nothing Phone (2a) comes with NothingOS 2.5 pre-installed, which sits atop Android 14. Nothing offers three years of software updates and four years of security patches, which is quite decent for its price range.

The user interface is minimalist yet feature-rich; animations are lightning-fast, daily operations run smoothly, and additional features such as Nothing Widgets, AI Wallpaper Generator, and Glyph Composer are well-implemented.

The absence of bloatware in the form of third-party apps and ads is a significant advantage; users only encounter a couple of Nothing apps along with the standard Google apps. This is a rarity, especially in the mid-range segment. Motorola has achieved a similar level of cleanliness, but some of their budget to mid-range phones do include a few third-party apps now.

I particularly appreciate the small touches Nothing has incorporated. Whether it's the recognizable Nothing shutter sound when taking a photo or the attention to detail in the screen lighting up from the point of touch when unlocked, all of these subtle enhancements contribute to a more premium user experience.

CAMERAS

The Nothing Phone (2a) packs a dual rear camera setup consisting of a 50 MP main sensor with OIS capabilities and a 50 MP ultrawide sensor with a

114-degree FOV. For selfies, Nothing has added a 32 MP camera, which is the exact same sensor as used on the more expensive Phone (2). Nothing has also implemented an advanced HDR software which they have co-developed with Google dubbed Ultra HDR.

There's also a feature called Motion Capture that is particularly useful for capturing moving objects, however, this was just mediocre in my testing. Nothing needs to tune the software better for this feature to actually work well with particularly difficult subjects such as dogs or kids.

Now, let's talk about the camera performance. The primary 50 MP camera is capable of clicking some pretty good-looking pictures in ideal lighting conditions. The detail retention is fantastic; all without looking artificially-sharpened. The colours are pretty close to natural as well. The dynamic range, while decent, can falter at times. There are instances where the highlights are not controlled enough.

One of the biggest disappointments is portrait shots. Most portraits have poor edge detection and the skin tones don't look very accurate. Additionally, in shots with harsh backlighting, the subject can look very washed out.

Low-light shots are surprisingly good though. You get crisp details and good colour reproduction. The dynamic range in the shadows and highlights could be better, but for the price, these are fantastic low-light shots. The 32 MP selfie camera takes impressive pictures with good detail and colour, not surprising as it has the same sensor as the Phone (2).

BATTERY LIFE

The Nothing Phone (2a) houses Nothing's largest battery in a phone to date. It is a massive 5,000 mAh cell with support for 45 W fast wired charging. Sadly, there's no charger in the box, which is a massive disadvantage for Nothing since all other similarly-priced phones come with their charging bricks in the box. There is also no wireless charging support.

The Phone (2a) is easily a one-day phone. During my testing, the phone

would be left at about 20 per cent battery at the end of the day. My day consisted of some benchmarking, social media, camera usage, and watching content on YouTube. In our 4K video loop test, the phone lasted over 13 hours, which is a pretty decent score. Charging the Phone (2a) to full isn't the fastest affair though; it took 62 minutes to top up to full.

VERDICT

The Nothing Phone (2a) is like a breath of fresh air, offering a smooth and bloatware-free experience in the competitive sub-₹25,000 price segment, which is a rarity. The design is polarising but gutsy, showcasing Nothing's desire to set itself apart. Adding to that, an impressive primary camera, decent battery life, and smooth performance, the Nothing Phone (2a) could easily appeal to Indian masses.

Nothing has claimed that the new Nothing Phone (2a) is an upgrade over the original Phone (1) at a more affordable launch price. While this is largely true due to an upgraded processor, slightly brighter screen, and a larger battery, there are some areas where it still lags behind. These include a plastic body, slower UFS 2.2 storage speeds, and the absence of wireless charging. So, while I don't think the Nothing Phone (2a) is a total upgrade over the Phone (1), it remains a fantastic option for those who want to experience a Nothing smartphone at a relatively affordable price, quirks and all.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: MediaTek Dimensity 7200 Pro | RAM: 8/12 GB LPDDR4X | Storage: 128/256 GB UFS 2.2 | Software support: 3 years Android updates + 4 years security patches | Glyph Interface: Yes, 26 individually addressable zones | Display: 6.7-inch AMOLED | Display resolution: 1084 x 2412 | Display refresh rate: 30-120 Hz adaptive refresh rate | Cameras (rear): 50 MP f/1.88 (OIS) + 50 MP f/2.2 | Camera (front): 32 MP f/2.2 | Battery capacity: 5,000 mAh | Charging: 45 W | IP rating: IP54 | Weight: 190 g

CONTACT

Company: Nothing | Phone: 18002021232 | Email: Web form | Website: <https://in.nothing.tech/>